

Order Refund Timing - Agent Knowledge Base

How to explain refund statuses, bank posting times, mixed tenders, overdue credits, and refund-trace escalation.

Prototype disclaimer

Synthetic sample policy for prototyping and RAG evaluation. This document is fictional operational guidance, not a statement of any real company's policy. Adapt, validate, and approve it before production use.

Retrieval metadata

Applies to: customer support agents, ticket triage agents, and automated support agents

Recommended ticket tags: refund_timing, refund_pending, refund_trace, store_credit_refund, closed_card

Policy status: synthetic / test corpus

Policy summary

Once Northstar Commerce issues a refund, the customer should usually see it within 5-10 business days after the refund is issued. The support system should distinguish between refund approved, refund issued, and refund posted by the customer's financial institution.

Core rule

Never count bank processing time before the refund has actually been issued. First verify the refund status and issue date in the order record.

Refund states

Approved = internal eligibility decision completed, but money may not have been sent yet. Issued = refund transaction submitted to the payment processor. Posted = customer's bank or wallet shows the credit. Failed = processor rejected or could not complete the refund.

Decision rules

Situation	Agent action	Escalate when
Refund approved but not issued	Explain that processing is not complete yet; check internal SLA.	Approved status remains more than 2 business days without issuance.
Refund issued fewer than 10 business days ago	Share issue date and ask customer to allow bank processing time.	Processor marks refund failed.
Refund issued more than 10 business days ago	Collect permitted transaction details and escalate for refund trace.	Always escalate for payment trace.
Customer used store credit	Refund store-credit portion back to store credit unless the order record explicitly shows a different method.	Credit balance is not restored within 24 hours.
Original payment method is closed	Refund must still be sent to original method unless processor offers an approved reroute. Customer should contact the issuer.	Processor returns the refund or issuer cannot route it.

Partial and mixed-payment refunds

If an order was paid with multiple sources, refund each portion to its original source where the platform supports it. Shipping charges are refunded only when the underlying return, damage, cancellation, or service policy makes them eligible.

Suggested ticket fields

issue_type=refund_timing; order_id; refund_id; refund_status=approved|issued|posted|failed; issue_date; refund_amount; destination=card|wallet|store_credit; business_days_elapsed; trace_required=yes|no

Frequently asked questions

Q: How long does a refund take?

A: After the refund is issued, allow 5-10 business days for most banks and card issuers to post it.

Q: You said my refund was approved. Why do I not see it?

A: Approval is not the same as issuance. Check whether the refund has an issued date before starting the bank-processing clock.

Q: It has been more than 10 business days. What now?

A: Escalate for a refund trace using the refund ID, issue date, amount, and destination method. Do not ask for full card details.

Q: My card account is closed. Will I lose the refund?

A: Refunds are normally sent to the original payment method. The issuer may route the credit to a replacement account or issue it another way. Escalate if the processor returns the refund.

Q: Why did I get store credit instead of cash?

A: A portion paid with store credit is normally returned to store credit. Check the original tender breakdown.

Q: Can you speed up the bank?

A: No. Once the refund is successfully issued, the posting timeline is controlled by the financial institution. Agents can trace an overdue refund but cannot force immediate posting.

Agent response principle

State what is known, distinguish it from what is estimated, give the customer the next concrete step, and never promise an outcome outside the rules in this knowledge base.